



Technische Hochschule
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Bachelor Thesis

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**Development of a Frontend Application for Real-Time and
24-Hour Monitoring and Recording of Electrocardiographic Data
with Communication via Bluetooth Low Energy**

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AFFIDAVIT

I hereby declare that I have written this thesis independently, have not used any sources or aids other than those stated, have not submitted it elsewhere for examination purposes and have expressly identified all quotations from the sources used, either verbatim or in spirit. I have marked verbatim and indirect quotations as such.

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ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

This is the sentimental part where you get to thank all the persons who were a part of your thesis journey in one or the other way!

Eric Horacsek
Ingolstadt, Deutschland
November xx 2024

ABSTRACT

The human heart is the central organ of the circulatory system and plays a vital role in supplying the body with oxygen and nutrients. Rhythmic contractions pump blood through the body, laying the foundation for all vital functions. An essential part of medical diagnostics combined with heart function and health is the electrocardiogram (ECG). The ECG measures the electrical activity of the heart and provides valuable information about the heart rhythm as well as possible irregularities or diseases. As technology has advanced, the way in which ECG data can be collected and monitored has also evolved significantly. Mobile health monitoring in particular now makes it possible to record ECG data not only at certain points of time, but also in real time and over longer periods of time. Wireless transmission via Bluetooth Low Energy (BLE) enables reliable and energy-efficient transfer of data to mobile devices. This opens up new possibilities for applications offering real-time and long term monitoring enabling users access to relevant information and graphical processing and alarm functions. This thesis explains the conception and implementation of an Android frontend application, which realises continuous and mobile ECG monitoring. The main programming language used for this project, is kotlin with Jetpack Compose as the Framework. Moreover this dissertation is particularly focused on implementing the communication and data transmission via BLE as well as realising an 24-hour-mode, which might be used for 24-hour data recognition. It also provides an broad insight into the given requirements, designprincipals, and technical challenges which accured during the implementation. Furthermore this theseis offers a glimpse into the potential for modern healthsuveillance.

CONFIDENTIALITYCLAUSE

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GLOSSARY

Eric Horacsek Absolute operation.

ACRONYMS

D Dimensions.

RGB Red Green Blue channels.

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1 INTRODUCTION

This chapter will give a small introduction on what the thesis and the implemented application is about. This covers an explanation for the application's motivation and the environment the application will be used in.

1.1 Motivation

The aim of this work is to create a new version of an Android App once developed by fellow students from the faculty of Electrical and Information Technology. It's core functionality is to receive and display ECG data in real time, via BLE. With the completion of this work, the new version will be able to receive and display ECG data in real time, via BLE. In addition it will be capable of an 24-hour mode which records ECG data for up to 24 hours, so the collected data can be analyzed later.

1.2 Scope and Framework

This paper only deals with the app development process of the new version. Therefore, any implementation of the previous work done by the students is not going to be discussed in detail. The hardware implementation is also not an element of this work . Generally speaking, this paper covers all topics that are essential for the development of the new app version. Specifically, technology stack of choice, IDE choice desicion, communication with hardware via Bluetooth low energy, structure of the user interface, real-time data monitoring, implementing the 24 hour mode. In addition, the outlook explains procedures for the implementation of future features that could not be realized within the limits of this paper.

1.3 Procedure

The second chapter, *Technical Fundamentals*, explores the key technologies chosen for this project, including the selected programming language, the integrated development environment (IDE), and their respective versions. Additionally, it provides a brief introduction to the Android architecture, with a particular focus on the Java Framework API. This chapter offers valuable insights into the core functionality of the operating system, laying the groundwork for a better understanding of the implementation details presented later. Chapter three delves into the functional requirements, systematically breaking them down into distinct sub-requirements. These requirements are revisited in chapter four, where they are translated into actual code, accompanied by relevant code snippets to illustrate their implementation.

2 TECHNICAL FUNDAMENTALS

"The nature of the application and the required functionality of a software system should influence the choice of methods and tools used during development". [Clarke \[1995\]](#) This ensures that the development process is both efficient and tailored to meet the unique demands of the system. Moreover, aligning tools and methods with the application's requirements can help streamline workflows and reduce potential complexities during implementation. Consequently choosing the right programming language, aswell as IDE is essential to enable efficient development.

The following chapter Technical Fundamentals contains all technical characteristics and requirements, and how they have been fulfilled.

2.1 Selected Technologies

2.1.1 Programming Language and Framework

When searching for a suitable programming language to program Android apps, names like Java/Kotlin and Dart often appear. Both languages offer great frameworks, such as Flutter for Dart or Jetpack Compose for Kotlin. One aswell as the other are highly effective because they eliminate the limitations of XML-based UI development, enabling a more streamlined, declarative approach that combines UI and logic in a single language. Thus reduces boilerplate code, and enhances performance aswell as developer productivity. The main difference between both frameworks lies in resource management. For example Flutter is superior in cpu usage, but Jetpack Compose consumes less memory. [Kusuma et al. \[2023\]](#) "But since both have their respective advantages and disadvantages, it is impossible to say that one is superior to the other. The choice between Jetpack Compose and Flutter depends on the needs and preferences of the developer. If developers are more familiar with the Kotlin language and want to use new technologies, then Jetpack Compose might be a better choice." [Kusuma et al. \[2023\]](#) With prior practical experience in Java/Kotlin, Jetpack Compose was chosen as the framework for this work.

2.1.2 Development Environment

Integrated development Environments play a fundamental role in today's application development, providing developer with tools mandatory to debug, refactor and write code. Making programming more efficient and delightful for programmers. When developing Android Apps with state of the art frameworks like Jetpack Compose, Android Studio stands out as the most suitable option as both Jetpack compose and Android Studio are

created by Google. Android Studio is the official IDE for Android Development. With IntelliJ as base it inherits powerful code editor and developer tools, combined with Android specific features. Such as Live Edit (updates running app when code is changed) as well as Interactive Preview which allows to test functionality between so called Compose components (Compose will be explained in the later course of this work)¹, et cetera.

The version of Android Studio used for this thesis is **Ladybug | 2024.2.1**. Which is the latest version as this was written (13.12.2024).² Downloading the right version can be crucial for problem-free debugging. As some versions lead to bugs, causing the screen to freeze.³

2.1.3 Versions

This section presents fundamental versions of the required development resources used for this work.

The tests for this application during the development process, were done on a phone using the **Android version 13** which implies the usage of **API level 33**. Utilizing lower Android version than 12 (API Level 31,32) is not possible due to new runtime permissions added in Android 13, making it impossible to start the app⁴. Higher Android versions were not reviewed. More versions of the used resources, are presented in table 1.

Table 1: Versions of used resources

Ressource	Version used
Android version	13
API Level	33
Koltin compiler extension version	5.15.1
minSDK	30

2.2 Android architecture

To program a platform-specific application, it can be important to understand the basic architecture of the platform, especially when dealing with tasks regarding memory or Bluetooth. This section will give a brief insight into the structure of the Android construction. Tasks discussed later in this thesis may reference this chapter to convey a better understanding.

¹<https://developer.android.com/studio/intro>

²<https://developer.android.com/studio/releases>

³<https://stackoverflow.com/questions/78125635/processing-classes-for-emulated-method-breakpoints-this-popup-comes-and-loadin>

⁴<https://developer.android.com/develop/connectivity/bluetooth/bt-permissions>

The core of the Android Platform is a Linux based kernel. On top of Android's Kernel are four more stack layers, such as the Hardware Abstraction Layer, Native Libraries/Android Runtime, Java API Framework and the uppermost layer, the System App layer. (also see: Figure 1). Going into detail for each stack layer is not necessary for this work, consequently only essential layers like the Java API Framework will be considered in more depth. A short introduction into each layer is given by table 2 and figure 1 .

Table 2: Layers explanation

Layer	Functionality
System App's (Application Layer)	This layer is a collection of preinstalled applications. Apps contained in this collection, have the same status at system level as third-party apps(system settings is the only exception). Giving the user freedom for design.
Java API Framework (Framework Layer)	Enables acces to all features of the Android OS, such as resource manager and view system.
Native Libraries	System components such as ART and HAL are written in C/C++, those functionalities can be used via API's
Android Runtime (ART)	Every running application is an instance of ART. ART operates on the same layer as Native Libraries
Hardware Abstraction Layer (HAL)	Provides interfaces to the Java API Framework, hence addressing hardware components like Camera or Bluetooth module is possible.
Linux Kernel	Foundation of the OS. Administrates system resources, and communicates with hardware.

A layered architecture like the Android OS, ensures modularity, maintainability and security. Each layer is designed with a specific responsibility, and communicates primarily with adjacent layers. Applications interact with the Framework layer via the Android SDK (bridge between Application Layer and Framework Layer), which provides access to core system services. The Framework, in turn, relies on the Native Libraries and Runtime layers for functionalities like graphics rendering, media playback, and app execution. Hardware communication is abstracted through the Hardware Abstraction Layer (HAL), which interfaces with the Linux Kernel. This structured separation of concerns enhances the system's flexibility, allowing independent evolution and optimization of each layer.

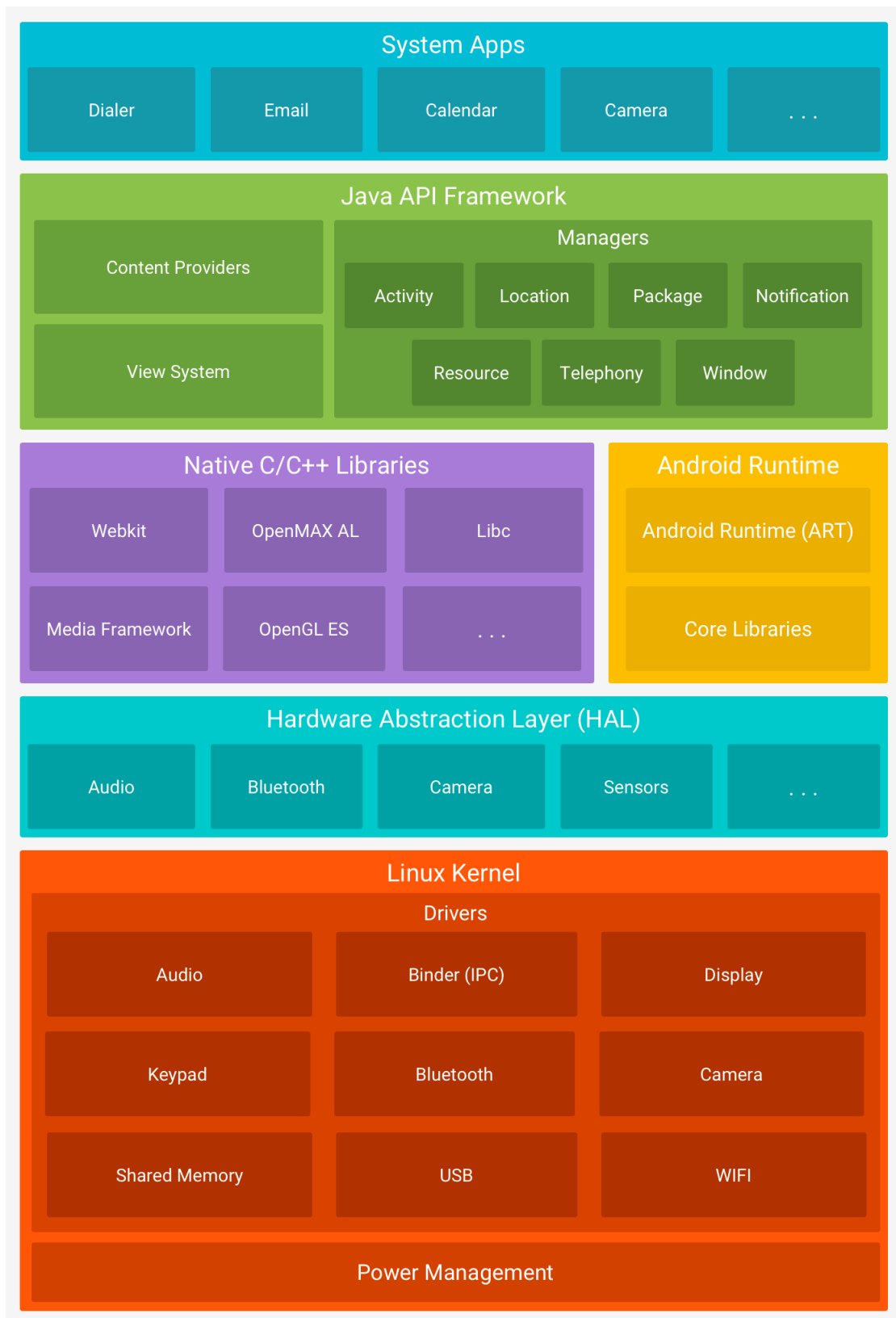


Figure 1: Android Platform architecture

2.2.1 Java Framework API (Framework Layer)

Description

As already mentioned in 2.2, the Android Java Framework API is a collection of libraries and tools provided by Android to simplify the development of mobile applications. Built on top of Java, it enables developers to create apps with pre-built components, utilities, and services that interact with the Android operating system. The framework abstracts the complexity of low-level operations and provides high-level APIs for features such as UI design, data storage, networking, and hardware access.

Project example

To provide an impression, Figure 2 shows a code excerpt in which the Java API was implicitly used by androidx. To keep this chapter manageable, it can be simplified said that androidx is a superset of the Java API Framework.

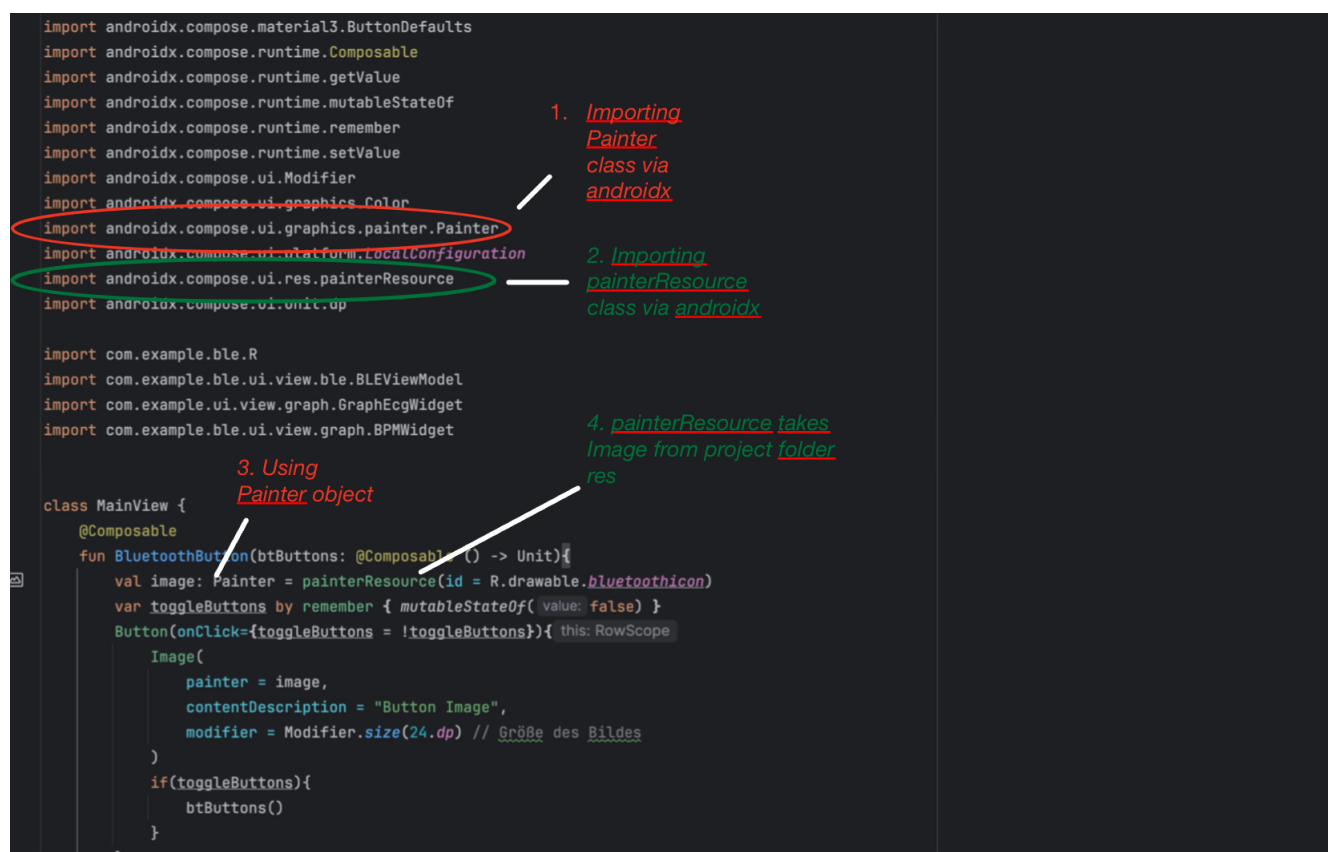


Figure 2: Android Java API example with androidx

Figure 2 provides a glimpse of the capabilities of the androidx library. Showing how to draw an image with the `Painter` class and utilizing the resource manager mentioned in table 2.

To begin its elementary to import the Painter class aswell as the painterResource class. As shown in 1. and 2. in Figure 2. Then at 3. a Painter object is created, at 4. the Painter object is defined by the painterResource function. The painterResource function gets an id as an argument, to query the file from the res/drawable folder. The res folder contains all additional app resources (files, images, etc.). Finally we can draw the Image by passing the object from 3. to an Image function.

3 FUNCTIONAL REQUIREMENTS

Requirement engineering is essential at the beginning of every project. Formulating and documenting precisely defined requirements is a cornerstone in the course of realization. In this way, mundane mistakes can be avoided and the vision of the final product is clear. Thus this chapter will explain all functional requirements of the finished product.

3.1 Drawing ECG-Data in realtime

To realize a realtime display of someones hearthrate, it is helpful to split this rather complex functionality into multiple concerns:

- The sample rate of the microcontroller (1)
- Consume and process incoming data at once (2)
- Datahandling and Drawing must happen in parallel (3)

After gaining a concicse overview over the issues, its now import to view and solve every issue isolated and subsequently combine each solved problem with the other. It is important to mention that some issues may create restrictions for other issues. Therefore, it is essential to implement one task at a time and connect them all afterward.

We now look at our problems in a rather theoretically way, to facilitate the implementation in the end.

(1) Handle The Sample rate of the microcontroller

The microcontroller sends 10 datapieces every 8 milliseconds ($1000\text{ms} = 1\text{s}$).

$$\frac{1000}{8} = \frac{125}{1} \hat{=} 125\text{Hz}$$

Hence we have to process a sample rate of: $f(t) = 125 \times t$, t in seconds. If handling this datastream is not possible, data will be lost.

(2)Consume and process incoming data at the same time

To consume and process data at the same time, we split up processing and consuming into two independent tasks by assigning each task to its own thread, making it possible to operate in parallel.

Since both threads have to access the same resource at the same time, we have to make use of mutual exclusion. The concept of mutual exclusion will be explained in the later course of this thesis.

(3) Datahandling and drawing in parallel

Thus the drawing entity has to continuously read data, and the datahandler entity receives a continuous data stream, one has to think of a fitting datastructure. The data structure must be able to constantly record new data and retain a certain amount of old data. So that a screen-width drawing can be displayed continuously. In addition, it is important that the data structure is not too large, which would lead to visible latencies.

This led to the Ringbuffer being the datastructure of choice. Ringbuffers are often used when having to process datastreams. Thus the old data gets overwritten by new data, the ringbuffer has a fixed size. Therefore, there is no need to worry about the data structure consuming too much memory.

3.2 24-Hour recording

The functional requirements of the 24-Hour recording are shown in the list below. All of the listed requirements will be explained in detail at the Implementation chapter.

- Recording mode
- Filechooser concept, to choose multiple files
- Start a recording, and assigning a name
- Abort a recording
- Display 24-Hour long recorded ECG-Data
- Show the current time intervals
- Zoom into the displayed data, zooming out of the displayed data
- Plot BPM of the current displayed time interval

3.3 Connection via Bluetooth Low Energy

The application is required to establish and maintain a reliable Bluetooth Low Energy (BLE) connection with the hardware. A stable connection is essential for continuous data-transfer as well as the 24-Hour recording Mode. The BLE entity must be able of the following items:

- Continuous datastream
- Communicate with the application
- Sharing current the current mode (realtime, or recording)
- Scan for near devices
- reassemble packages that are too large

4 REALIZATION

The first part of this chapter provides an overview of the information flow between each entity, and the tasks of the given entities. As well as a close look into the implementation of the functional requirements, by analysing code snippets, as well as explaining the usage of the final product. While the second part will explain every necessity to assemble all parts together for a working product.

4.1 Definition of Entitys

As shown in table 3 each entity has its scope of duties, making the final code more modular and consequently maintainable.

Table 3: Entiys area of responsibility

Layer	Functionality
BLEViewModel	- Communication with the microcontroller - Receives datastream - Sends instructions to microcontroller
GraphEcgWidget	Draws the ECG data in realtime, and displays Beats per minute
Storewrapper	Converts data from microcontroller into drawble data
BPM	Calculates the current Beats Per Minute
VitalMonitorWidet	Plots up to 24 Hour long recoreded ECG data and the BPM of the plotted Intervall. Provides zooming functionality.
StorageHandler	Allows usage of the OS filechooser, to select files.
MainView	Collection of visble elements (Widgets), to provide reusability
MainActivity	Visible to user, contains the complete User Interface. Takes and processes user inputs.

4.2 Inter-Entity Communication Overview

The following diagram shows the Information flow between all entities. The unidirectional arrow means that, information is flowing oneside. An informationexchange between two entities is represented by an bidirectional arrow.

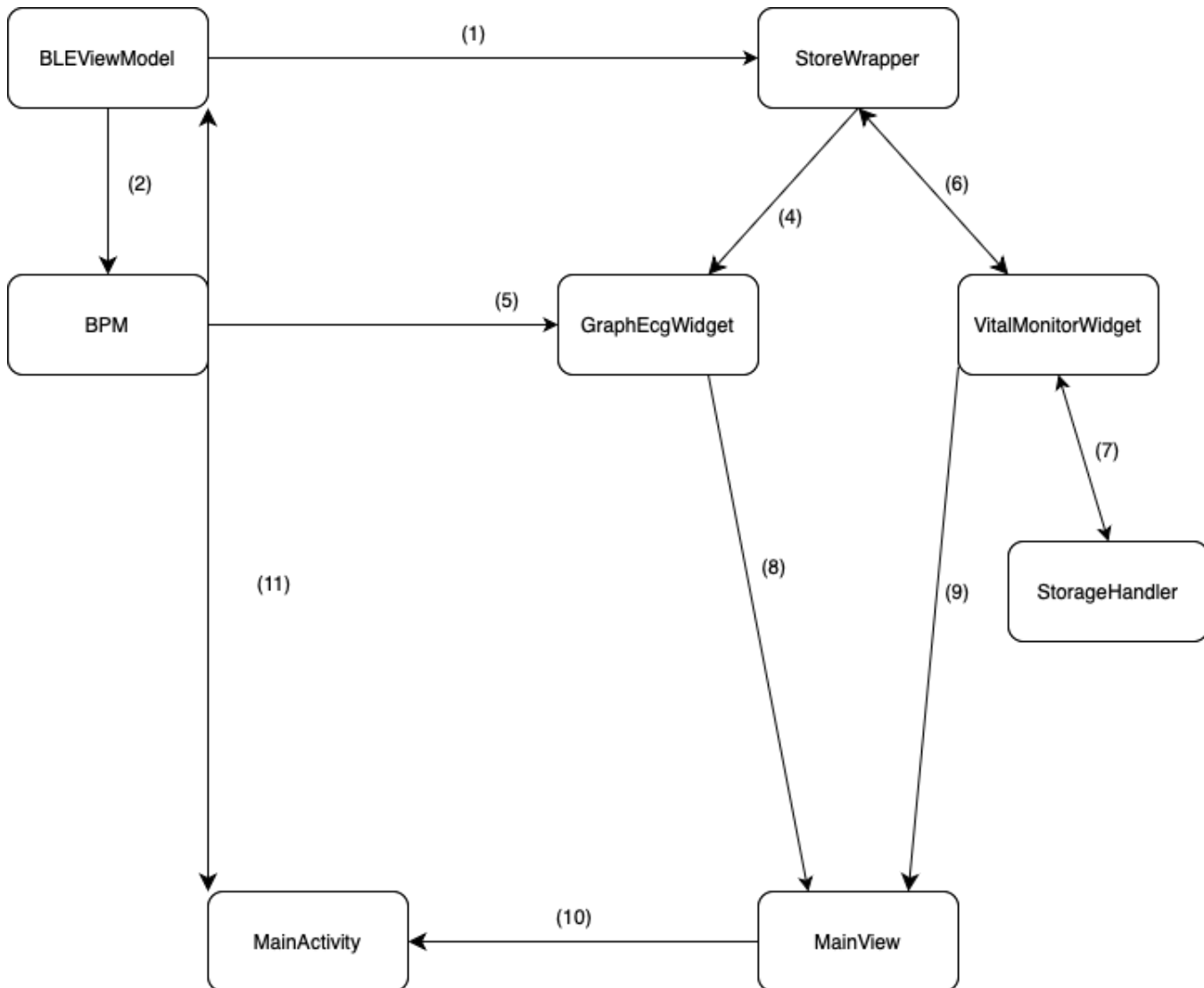


Figure 3: Informationflow Diagramm

As already stated in 4.1 the BLEViewModel entity, serves as an interface between controller and app. Therefore every entity that needs to evaluate recorded data, is dependent on this Instance. Two of the entities listed in 4.1 are affected. To be more precise, it is the StoreWrapper that makes the data drawable (1) and forwards the data to the GraphECGWidget (4). The BPM instance that calculates the beat frequency (2), (which

is then displayed by the GraphECGWidget (5)). Informationflow (6), in contrast to (5), is bidirectional. This is necessary because the recorded data needs to be read, by the StorageHandler from a local file (7), before being sent to the Storewrapper (6). After the data has been mapped by the Storewrapper, it is sent back to the VitalMonitorWidget (6). MainView integrates both the GraphECGWidget (8) and the VitalMonitorWidget (9) as components and manages their visibility. However, the range of tasks of the BLE-ViewModel is not limited to exchanging data, but also extends to scanning and connecting with other devices in the vicinity, as well as integrating and managing a 24-hour ECG recording. These functionalities are utilized by the MainView and the MainActivity. As already mentioned in table 3, MainView serves solely to construct components of functionalities that are later utilized by MainActivity, such as buttons enabling users to start a 24-hour ECG recording (10). The MainActivity entity acts as a bridge between the microcontroller and the user, allowing device scanning, initiating recordings, establishing connections, and displaying ECG information (11).

(Usage and) Logic

The following subsections explore the logical implementation and functionality of individual entities, using code snippets and application screenshots for illustration. Each subsection is divided into a section covering the implementation and another focusing on the application's usage, with both sections referring to corresponding screenshots. Framework specific code fragments will be explaining in the course of relevant section.

4.3 BLEViewModel

Before presenting the implementation of the BLE component, it is essential to establish a fundamental theoretical understanding of BLE. This section offers a comprehensive explanation of the Bluetooth Low Energy, shedding light on its core principles, while exploring the architecture of the BLE stack.

4.3.1 BLE Stack

The BLE protocol stack consists of three main layers: the Controller, the Host, and the Application. The Controller encompasses the Physical Layer and the Link Layer, while the Host manages higher-level functionalities such as the Logical Link Control and Adaptation Protocol (L2CAP), the Attribute Protocol (ATT), the Generic Attribute Profile (GATT), the Security Manager (SM), and the Generic Access Profile (GAP). Communication between the Host and the Controller follows the standardized Host Controller Interface (HCI). At the top of the stack, the Application layer enables program execution.

Dian et al. [2018]

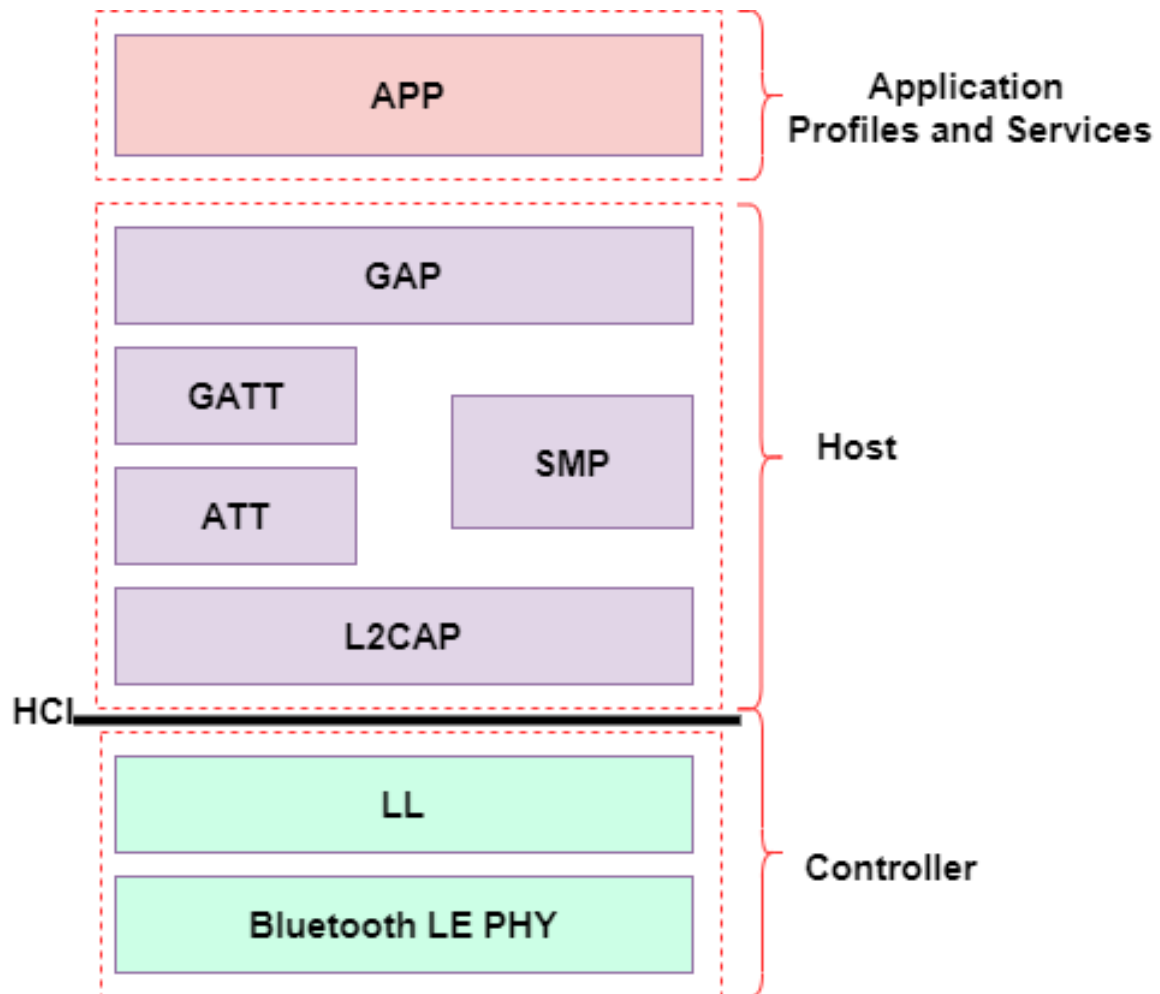


Figure 4: BLE protocol stack (<https://de.mathworks.com/help/bluetooth/gs/bluetooth-protocol-stack.html>)

Application Layer

The application layer serves as the direct user interface, defining profiles that enable interoperability between various applications.

Host Layer

Includes the host-sided HCI as well as L2CAP, ATT, GATT, SMP and GAP.

Generic Access Profile (GAP)

Manages the connection setup as well as security, interfaces directly with profiles and services of the Application Layer.

Security Manager Protocol (SMP)

Provides multiple security algorithms for encrypting and decrypting data packets, making the connection secure.

Generic Attribute Profile (GATT)

Defines services and characteristics provided by the GATT Server. The GATT Server in this case is the microcontroller, which holds the definitions of services and characteristics. These can be requested by the GATT Client (in this case the application). Services organize data into logical entities and contain specific data units known as characteristics. Each service can include one or more characteristics and is uniquely identified by a numeric UUID. This UUID can be either 16-bit for officially adopted BLE services or 128-bit for custom services. Whereas the Characteristic is the lowest level concept in GATT transactions, which defines data. Services as well as Characteristics are main interaction points to work with when working with the BLE periphery, thus it is important to understand these terminologies.

Attribute Protocol (ATT)

The ATT enables the exchange of attributes (characteristics). Attributes are composed of four components, the type (128-bit UUID), an handle (16-bit identifier) to reference attributes, rights of the attribute (reading, writing), and the value of the attribute. The following figure gives a good overview of the structure of the attributes.

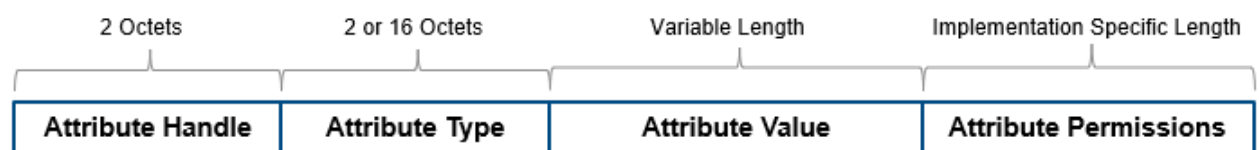


Figure 5: Attribute Structure (<https://de.mathworks.com/help/bluetooth/gs/bluetooth-protocol-stack.html>)

Logical Link Control and Adaption Layer Protocol (L2CAP)

Works as an interface between the HCI and the upper modules of the Host layer, by multiplexing data packets to the corresponding protocols. Also fragments and reassembles large packets.

Host-Side Host-Controller-Interface (HCI)

Generally said the HCI is the interface between the host and the controller. The HCI establishes commands and events for packet data transmission and reception. When sending data, it processes raw information into packets, enabling communication between the host and the controller.

Controller-Side Host-Controller-Interface (HCI)

As mentioned in the last paragraph, the HCI is the interface between the host and the controller. However, analogous to the host side, the data received from the controller is extracted and forwarded to the host.

Controller Layer

Includes the Bluetooth Le PHY, LL, and controller-side HCI

Link Layer (LL)

The LL functions similarly to the medium access control (MAC) layer in the OSI model. In Bluetooth, it directly interacts with the Bluetooth LE PHY and controls the radio's link state, determining whether a device operates as a Central, Peripheral, Advertiser, or Scanner.

Bluetooth LE PHY

The physical layer (BLE PHY) is a 1 Mbps GFSK-based radio with adaptive frequency hopping, operating in the unlicensed 2.4 GHz ISM (industrial, scientific, and medical) band.

4.3.2 Implementation

Dependency versions and Library

Before delving into the implementation, it is essential to note that a library provided by Nordic Semiconductor was employed in the development process.⁵ The utilized dependency version are shown in the figure below:

⁵<https://github.com/NordicSemiconductor/Android-BLE-Library>


```

implementation("no.nordicsemi.android.kotlin.ble:scanner:1.1.0")
implementation("no.nordicsemi.android.kotlin.ble:client:1.1.0")
implementation("no.nordicsemi.android.kotlin.ble:advertiser:1.1.0")
implementation("no.nordicsemi.android.kotlin.ble:server:1.1.0")
implementation("no.nordicsemi.android:ble:2.4.0")
implementation("org.jetbrains.kotlinx:kotlinx-coroutines-core:1.6.0")
implementation("io.coil-kt:coil-compose:2.2.2")
implementation("androidx.collection:collection:1.4.3")

```

Figure 6: Library Versions

Scanning devices

First of all we are exploring the *scanning functionality*, to register nearby devices.

```

private var scanJob: Job? = null

@RequiresApi(Build.VERSION_CODES.UPSIDE_DOWN_CAKE)
@SuppressLint("MissingPermission")
private fun startScan(context: Context) {
    scanState.value = ScanState.SCANNING
    foundBLEDevices.value = mutableSetOf()

    val aggregator = BleScanResultAggregator()
    scanJob = BleScanner(context).scan()
        .map { aggregator.aggregateDevices(it) }
        .onEach { it: List<ServerDevice>
            foundBLEDevices.value = it.stream()
                .filter { it.name == "THI-EKG" }
                .collect(Collectors.toSet())
        }
        .launchIn(viewModelScope)

    viewModelScope.launch { this: CoroutineScope
        delay( timeMillis: 2000)
        scanJob?.cancel()
        scanState.value = ScanState.DONE
    }
}

```

Figure 7: Scanning functionality code

LITERATURE REFERENCES

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